

# The Global Burden of Mental Illness

## Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

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A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions, their disease burden, and the persistent gap between need and treatment.

Source: Our World in Data • IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) • Data Year: 2023

# Hundreds of Millions Affected

Lifetime risk of major depression by sex

**1 in 3**

**WOMEN**

will experience major depression

**1 in 5**

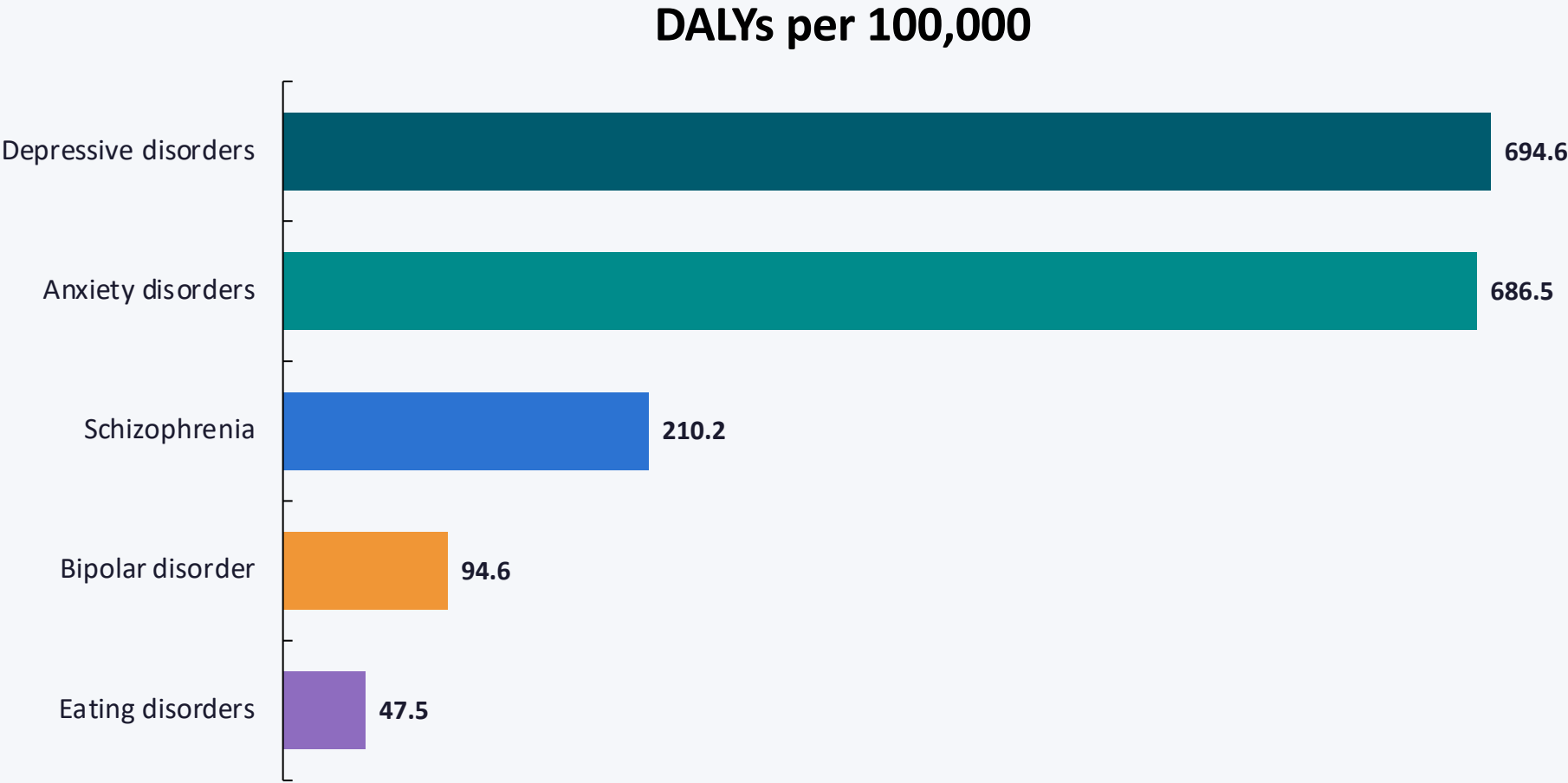
**MEN**

will experience major depression

Mental health conditions range from highly prevalent disorders — depression and anxiety — to less common but severely disabling conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder. Understanding this spectrum is critical for effective policy design and resource allocation.

# Depression and Anxiety Dominate the Mental Health Burden

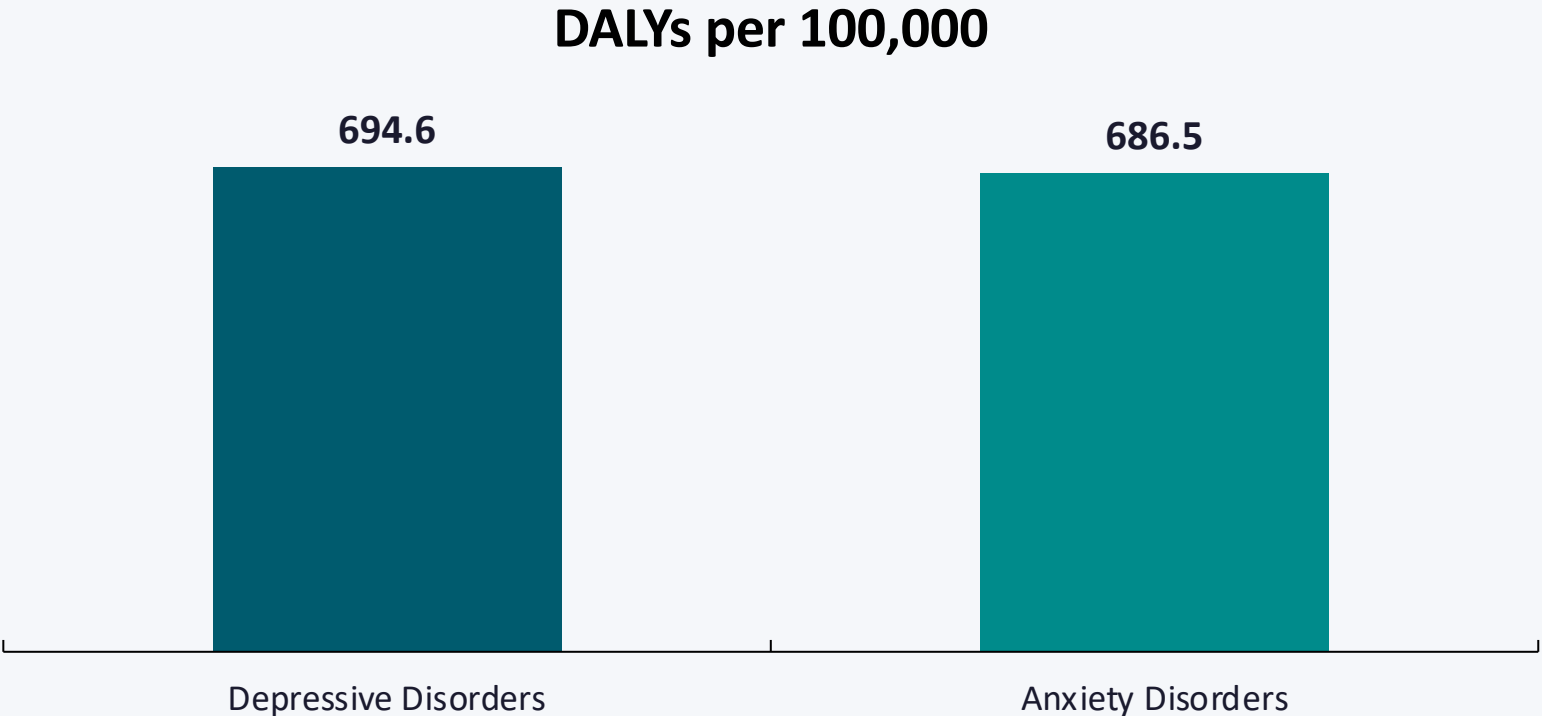
DALYs per 100,000 people by mental illness category, World, 2023



Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) via Our World in Data

# Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people, World, 2023



**Combined, depression and anxiety account for ~80% of the total mental health disease burden** across the five major categories. Their near-equal magnitude demands co-equal policy attention.

# Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder: Lower Prevalence, Severe Impact

DALYs per 100,000 people — comparing population-level burden across categories



While schizophrenia and bipolar disorder affect fewer people at the population level, the individual burden is disproportionately high. Schizophrenia contributes 210.2 DALYs per 100,000 — reflecting severe, long-term disability that demands specialized care.

Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) via Our World in Data

# Treatment Is Available — but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable, yet significant barriers prevent adequate care for hundreds of millions.



## STIGMA

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know.



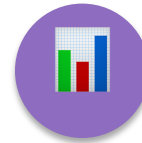
## ACCESS

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries where resources are scarce.



## QUALITY

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality, limiting its effectiveness for patients.



## UNDERREPORTING

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate true prevalence — the actual burden is likely higher.

# How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations

Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression



## Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where healthcare systems provide access to pharmacological treatments for depression and anxiety.



## Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide. Faith-based coping reflects deep cultural ties between spirituality and mental well-being.



## Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across cultures. Social support networks remain a critical first line of response.

**The diversity of coping strategies underscores that mental health responses are shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Policy interventions must account for these differences.**

# Key Takeaways

## Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

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1

Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority (~80%) of mental health DALYs across the five major disorder categories.

2

Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry a disproportionately high individual burden relative to their prevalence, demanding specialized care resources.

3

Effective treatments exist, but access and quality remain deeply inadequate, especially in low- and middle-income countries.

4

Stigma suppresses both help-seeking behavior and accurate data collection, meaning the true burden is likely higher than current estimates suggest.

5

Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.